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GRAB AND GO TRAINING IDEAS

Activity	Digital Components	Instructional Tips	Sector-Specific
Present participants with a variety of digital devices (e.g., laptop, desktop, tablet, smartphone) or platforms (e.g., Facebook, TikTok, Instagram, Twitter). Ask participants to identify their common functions and features, teaching appropriate terminology as required. Then provide examples of workplace tasks and have groups select the digital tool that is best suited to the task and present their rationale.	1. Use digital devices including computers, tablets, smart phones, and other handheld devices • *Identify and use the basic functions common to most devices* • *Know the basic terminology common to most digital devices* 2. Use common digital tools to complete tasks • *Select appropriate digital tools based on your goals and purposes of tasks*	Incorporate digital devices and platforms that align to participants' interests, needs and career goals. Comparing tools of a similar type (e.g. different social media platforms or presentation software) will help develop transferable skills and familiarity with the tools of a particular field.	Select digital devices, platforms and tools that are used within the sector.  Taking on the role of marketing manager, participants decide which social media would be the most effective advertising platform to reach a target audience.
Discuss the topic of evaluating websites for relevance and reliability and why it's important. Provide participants with criteria for evaluating online information. Then give groups a list of websites to evaluate according to the criteria. Encourage them to discuss their findings and reasoning. Debrief together as a group to check understanding.	3. Use digital information • *Evaluate the relevance and reliability of digital information*	Adapt the activity to include other types of relevant digital information, such as social media, podcasts, etc. Adjust the complexity of the evaluation criteria depending on participant abilities.	Contextualize the sources of online information to the sector.  Have participants evaluate a variety of online medical information sources, such as the Ministry of Health, hospitals, charities, private sites, Wikipedia, social media posts, etc.
Ask participants what they know about password security. Elicit the do's and don'ts of creating strong passwords. Provide an informal quiz of sample passwords, asking participants to determine if they are strong or weak passwords. Debrief as a group, encouraging participants to explain their answers. Follow up with strategies to help participants generate and remember strong passwords for their own digital purposes.	5. Apply safe and responsible practices online • *Understand best practices in data storage and sharing* • *Protect personal information and privacy of yourself and others* • *Protect data and devices from online risks and threats* • *Make secure online transactions*	Model the reading skills required to gather data for each demographic. Model alternate methods for calculating percents, step-by-step. Encourage learners to try both methods. Building bar graphs may be easier than pie charts. Provide the gradation for the y-axis. Use graph paper. This activity can integrate Digital skills: you can teach how to use common software (Word, Excel) to create graphic displays.	Integrate safe and responsible practices specific to the sector.  Talk to industry SMEs about typical digital safety protocols in manufacturing. What are the risks? What measures are in place to protect personal information and privacy? What are the consequences if digital safety is compromised?

Problem Solving

Problem Solving is the ability to identify, analyze, propose solutions and make decisions.

Why are Problem-Solving Skills Important?

Every day you use information to make decisions, solve problems, and take actions. This can include thinking about different ways to complete a task and choosing the best solution, or deciding what to do first when several activities are competing for your attention. The ability to think, make decisions, and solve problems effectively improves the way you carry out activities, and meet goals and deadlines at work or in other daily life situations.

Problem Solving Components

1. Identify the issue to be addressed
2. Gather information to help you address the issue
3. Analyze the issue
4. Develop multiple routes of action
5. Address the issue
6. Evaluate the effectiveness of the solution or decision

Research Report to Support the Launch of Skills for Success (p. 23)

Sector	Workplace Examples
 Construction	Electricians learn how to troubleshoot and repair difficult electrical faults by reading manuals, studying electrical schematics, accessing information on web forums and blogs and by speaking with co-workers, other tradespeople, electrical engineers and manufacturers.
 Manufacturing	Manufacturing Technicians experience equipment breakdowns and malfunctions, which shut down or slow production. The technician works with the machine operator to complete troubleshooting procedures on the equipment.
 Tourism	Guest Services Representatives encounter problems when appointments have been overbooked or clients have cancelled appointments on short notice. Appointments must be re-scheduled to best fit staff and client needs.
 Education	Early Childhood Educators cannot complete planned learning activities when children are unmanageable. They attempt to engage them using other toys and alternative activities. They may isolate misbehaving and aggressive children, explain expected behaviors and assign appropriate consequences.

Transitioning from Essential Skills to Skills for Success

The Essential Skills Framework included the skill of Thinking. In Skills for Success, Thinking has been changed to Problem Solving, incorporating the components of Finding Information, Critical Thinking and Decision Making. This change redefined the skill to resonate better with users.

Practitioners can teach these thinking components within a problem-solving framework. The problem-solving components are process-oriented, identifying the key skills and steps required to complete a problem-solving task. This is a helpful update since the Essential Skills framework did not provide processes for a learner or practitioner to follow.

Evidence-Based Instructional Strategies

The following instructional strategies have been selected to highlight established or promising practices within the Skills for Success field and/or significant research that supports the instruction of problem-solving skills.

1 Problem-Based Learning

Problem-based learning has participants acquire skills and knowledge through solving problems. Research has shown that this method is more effective than a lecture-based approach to teaching problem-solving skills. Problem-based instruction models have also been proven to be better at engaging and motivating students.

Instructional Strategies:

- Have participants solve problems in their workplace. This approach benefits learners as well as employers. Participants can apply problem-solving concepts in a familiar and relevant context and employers get a return on their training investment in the positive results of participant projects.
- Provide guidance and support as the participants problem solve. Use questions to help the students navigate the problem-solving process and reflect on their decisions. Avoid sole reliance on the discovery method as the minimally guided pure discovery approach tends to be ineffective.

Learning Transfer



Find opportunities to engage with employers and community members to prepare for learning transfer.

Implementation Guidance (p. 134)

- To support review and reflection, have students document the problem, the process involved in solving the problem and the solution. This will help them recall the steps they used and remember how to solve similar problems in the future.



Practitioner Competency Framework

- SFS 2.2 Contextualizes Skills for Success training to make learning relevant and practical
- SFS 3.6.5 Provides instruction on thinking strategies to choose the best course of action and evaluate its effectiveness
- SFS 3.6.6 Provides participants with sufficient time to work through problem-solving steps and find their own solutions
- SFS 3.6.7 Intervenes in problem-solving activities to provide structured guidance, feedback and questions, rather than leaving participants solely to the discovery method

2 Use Problem-Solving Models

Successful problem solving requires the use of a problem-solving strategy or model. Participants should be taught structured methods for solving problems that reflect the steps of the problem-solving components: identify the issue to be addressed, gather information to help you address the issue, analyze the issue, develop multiple routes of action, address the issue, and evaluate the effectiveness of the solution or decision. These models should be taught to learners before they engage in problem solving.

Instructional Strategies:

- Break down the problem-solving model into steps. This will help scaffold the learning by breaking the process into manageable steps that are within the range of participant competence. Problem solving can overwhelm learners without this step-by-step approach.
- Provide instruction on various tools that can be used during different steps in the problem-solving process. For example, incorporate fishbone diagrams and the 5 Whys activity to analyze the issue.
- Emphasize the importance of gathering information and analyzing the issue. Inexperienced problem solvers often develop routes of action before completing a proper analysis, leading to incomplete and ineffective solutions.



Practitioner Competency Framework

- SFS 3.6.1 Provides explicit instruction on the basic elements and procedures of problem-solving
- SFS 3.6.2 Uses problem-solving models that provide systematic processes for participants to follow

3 Group Learning

Problem solving in groups allows students to understand their own biases through the exploration of different perspectives. Group learning also helps participants develop other social-emotional Skills for Success like communication and collaboration.

Instructional Strategies:

- Have students practice brainstorming in a group. Go over best practices to ensure all voices in the group are heard. Brainstorming is an important component in workplace problem solving as many workplace issues involve multiple stakeholders.
- Group learning also presents an opportunity for role play. Problem solving in the workplace is often focused on resolving interpersonal conflict. Having two members of a group role play resolving a conflict while another member evaluates their approach is an effective strategy for beginning a discussion on conflict resolution. Problem solving in a team often involves negotiating and compromise and role play can be an effective way to develop these skills.

Engagement

Strategically integrate social-emotional Skills for Success into training to maximize learning and skill gains.

Implementation Guidance (p. 111)

- Explore cognitive bias by having students identify the influences behind their opinions about a problem or solution. Students can then discuss the differences between their perspectives to gain an appreciation for the value of diverse views when approaching a problem.

Under represented Groups



Practitioner Competency Framework

- SFS 3.6.3 Provides instruction on cognitive biases and how they can hamper successful problem solving
- SFS 3.6.9 Provides opportunities for participants to compare each other's work and critique alternative problem-solving strategies
- SFS 3.6.10 Integrates discussion, brainstorming and collaboration into problem-solving activities

Assessment Considerations

Assessment models for Problem Solving are still under development. *The Research Report to Support the Launch of Skills for Success* (2021) outlines the pros and cons of several methods, such as task-based assessments, situational judgement tests, and subjective reports (see Table 2, pp. 55-56). Assessments that are most likely to be used in training programs will need to strike a balance between rigour and usability.

Suggested approaches:

- Use scoring rubrics to assess performance-based tasks
  - Checklist ratings may allow for better standardization
  - Holistic ratings capture overall feeling and nuance
- Develop a self-reporting rubric for participants, coordinating with the instructional scoring rubric. Self-assessment is an important component of efforts to develop problem-solving skills.

Proficiency Levels:

Proficiency levels are the level at which a person demonstrates a particular skill. These levels help practitioners build assessment tools to measure participant's skills. The Office of Skills for Success will refine the proficiency levels over time.

Preliminary Proficiency Levels

Entry: You can make decisions or solve problems when there are limited or familiar variables, all the information is provided, and the stakes are low with few consequences. You can use your general knowledge and skills to process information, do simple or routine troubleshooting if needed, identify the decision or solution, and confirm the issue is resolved.

Intermediate: You can make decisions or solve problems when there are multiple well-defined variables, information is not provided but easily identified, and the stakes are moderate with some consequences. You are able to identify useful information sources, analyze the information, select the best option from multiple choices, and evaluate the effectiveness of the solution or decision based on given or standard criteria.

Advanced: You can make decisions or solve problems when there are many complex unfamiliar variables that can be unpredictable or contradictory, little information is provided or certain, and the stakes are high with significant consequences. You can search for information using diverse unfamiliar sources or conduct your own research, synthesize and analyze complex information to determine multiple options, select the best option, and determine how to assess the effectiveness of the process and solution or decision.

Research Report to Support the Launch of Skills for Success (p. 47)

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GRAB AND GO TRAINING IDEAS

Activity	Problem Solving Components	Instructional Tips	Sector-Specific
Create a scenario or have participants brainstorm a problem they could encounter on the job. Have the learners apply the steps of a problem solving strategy to the scenario or problem. The participants should work in groups so they can develop communication and collaboration skills and learn how to compromise, understand diverse perspectives and advocate for their ideas.	1. Identify the issue to be addressed 2. Gather information to help you address the issue 3. Analyze the issue • *Identify possible cause-and-effect linkages* 4. Develop multiple routes of action • *Create multiple options for action* 5. Address the issue 6. Evaluate the effectiveness of the solution or decision	Provide explicit instructions on the problem solving steps at the start of the activity. Have the participants identify the facts and influences that support their view of the problem to help navigate differences and understand cognitive bias. Provide explicit instruction on the basic elements and procedures of problem solving (SFS 3.6.1).	Contextualize the scenario to the sector. Sample scenario for Welders: A culture of bullying on your crew has led to multiple resignations in the last year. Apply the problem solving strategy to this issue.
Create a scenario or have participants brainstorm sources of interpersonal conflict in their industry. Have the participants generate a list of questions they could ask to understand the different sides of the conflict. Discuss how the different parties might respond to the questions. Brainstorm different ways the conflict could be resolved based on the responses.	4. Develop multiple routes of action • *Create multiple options for action* 5. Address the issue • *Use thinking strategies to choose the best course of action*	Have the participants role play the conflict after the discussion. Discuss active listening skills like paraphrasing, asking questions, eye contact, and not interrupting. Integrate discussion, brainstorming and collaboration into problem-solving activities (SFS 3.6.10).	Contextualize the scenario to the sector. Sample scenario for Travel Agents: A customer's flight was not booked correctly and now they need to wait an extra day to fly home. They are looking for compensation.
Participants are given a problem that is common in their industry. Have the participants brainstorm how they could measure and quantify the impact of the problem. Then have the participants identify the people in an organization that would be affected by the problem and what questions they could ask them to understand their view of the problem.	2. Gather information to help you address the issue • *Conduct research and collect relevant information* • *Seek help from others if needed*	Discuss the difference between tangible (increased costs) and intangible (reduced employee morale) impacts of a problem. Intervene in problem-solving activities to provide structured guidance, feedback and questions, rather than leaving participants solely to the discovery method (SFS 3.6.7).	Contextualize the scenario to the sector. Sample scenario for Machine Operators: The members of your team are consistently not following standard operating procedures, which has led to an increase in errors, waste, and injuries. Work with management and human resources to determine trends in hiring for entry positions. Adapt or reconfigure training models to be more effective for the likely new hires.

Communication

Communication is the ability to receive, understand, consider, and share information and ideas through speaking, listening and interacting with others.

Why are Communication Skills Important?

Strong communication skills help you share information in a way that others can clearly understand. You also need strong communication skills to listen to, pay attention to and understand others. In all jobs, communication skills are important for developing good working relationships with co-workers and clients, including those from different backgrounds and cultures. You also need these skills to work effectively in a team, understand a variety of viewpoints, and to gather and share information while problem solving – whether at work or in your daily life.

Communication Components

1. Listen with intention
2. Listen to understand
3. Speak with clarity
4. Speak with purpose
5. Adapt to your audience and contexts
6. Adapt to other people's different communication modes and tools

Research Report to Support the Launch of Skills for Success (p. 25)

Sector	Workplace Examples
Construction	Plumbers talk to customers to respond to questions and complaints, gather information about needed repairs, explain plumbing procedures and discuss the results of inspections and repairs.
Manufacturing	Manufacturing Labourers participate in staff meetings to discuss improvements in work processes.
Tourism	Hotel Front Desk Clerks interact with guests to deal with errors, complaints and emergencies. For example, they use tact to calm and negotiate with guests upset over reservation errors.
Food Processing	Quality Control Technicians communicate with the quality manager to provide progress reports and troubleshoot complex problems.

Transitioning from Essential Skills to Skills for Success

The Essential Skills Framework included the skill of Oral Communication. In Skills for Success, it has been changed to Communication to include broader concepts, such as non-verbal communication.

While listening was an element of Oral Communication, the name change and revised description of Communication in Skills for Success allows for greater emphasis on the role of listening and interpreting the communication of others, including intercultural aspects.

Practitioners can update their existing Essential Skills training materials by adding or re-emphasizing non-verbal cues, active listening, and intercultural competency.

Evidence-Based Instructional Strategies

The following instructional strategies have been selected to highlight established or promising practices within the Skills for Success field and/or significant research that supports the instruction of communication skills.

1 Intercultural Competence

Intercultural competence is the ability to interact effectively and appropriately with people across different cultures. This ability is increasingly important in Canada's diverse workplaces. In fact, as culture affects every component of communication, practitioners can improve skill gains by providing explicit instruction on the intercultural elements of communication.



Under represented Groups

Instructional Strategies:

- Provide opportunities for training participants to reflect on their own cultural identities and worldviews. Incorporate self-assessment exercises for participants to identify their progress along the continuum of intercultural competence. Cultural self-awareness is an important starting point for understanding other cultures.
- Encourage participants to share their own observations about similarities and differences in communication across cultures, including non-verbal aspects, such as tone of voice, facial expression, body language, etc. Participants can build culture-specific knowledge from the lived experiences of their peers.
- Use discussion, role-plays, and perspective-taking models to analyze miscommunications, unconscious bias, and/or different cultural interpretations. Incorporate workplace scenarios based on participants' career goals to improve learning transfer from the training room to the workplace.

Learning Transfer



Develop teaching tools and resources that support continued application of Skills for Success in new learning and working contexts.

Implementation Guidance (p. 133)



Practitioner Competency Framework

- SFS 3.8.3 Provides instruction on intercultural communication skills
- SFS 3.8.6 Provides instruction on non-verbal aspects of communication
- SFS 3.8.7 Creates learning tasks that require participants to consider their own and others' perspectives, biases, purposes and intentions

2 Active Listening

Active listening incorporates the first two components of communication: listen with intention and listen to understand. Active listening requires making a conscious effort to hear not only the words that are being said but the complete message that is being communicated. Active listeners are engaged and responsive participants in the conversation.

Active listening skills are critical on the job but sometimes overlooked as a communication skill. Workers with strong active listening skills ask questions to clarify information and paraphrase the message to demonstrate understanding.

Instructional Strategies:

- Provide explicit instruction on active listening skills, such as paraphrasing, verbalizing emotions, summarizing, clarifying, prompting and asking questions. Provide or elicit examples of what active listeners say (verbal) and do (non-verbal). For example, active listeners check that they understand (e.g., "Sounds like you are saying… Is that right?") and demonstrate interest (e.g., with nodding, smiling, eye contact, etc.)
- Incorporate mindful listening strategies to help participants become aware of distractions and refocus on the speaker's message. Being fully present, simplifying their surroundings, and using relaxation techniques can help participants concentrate and listen more effectively (Scott, 2010).
- Practice active listening as a practitioner to develop relationships with your training participants. Participants are often keen to share their experiences with their instructors and peers. Where possible, try to integrate what you learn about their backgrounds and experiences into learning activities. Developing the active listening skills of both participants and practitioners helps cultivate a safe, welcoming and inclusive learning environment.

Engagement



Create safe learning spaces by leveraging the social emotional Skills for Success to build learners' self-efficacy, autonomy, and confidence.

Implementation Guidance (p. 109)



Practitioner Competency Framework

- SFS 3.8.2 Provides instruction on techniques to improve active listening skills
- SFS 3.8.6 Provides instruction on non-verbal aspects of communication
- DELIVER 1.2 Creates an atmosphere that addresses the social-emotional needs of participants
- DELIVER 2.3.4 Listens actively to participants by focusing attention, nodding, asking clarification questions and soliciting responses

3 Role-play and Simulations

Role-play and simulation-based approaches are frequently cited as a best practice within the research on communication skill training. These activities allow participants to apply what they have learned in theory to real-world and workplace-based situations within the safety of the training room. Role-plays and simulations are effective approaches to teach any of the communication skill components, as well as other social-emotional Skills for Success (e.g., collaboration, problem solving and adaptability).

Instructional Strategies:

- Focus role-plays and simulation activities on the communication tasks participants are most likely to encounter on the job. Use occupational profiles, interviews with managers and workers, and other research to determine which communication tasks that are most frequent and critical to the job.
- Clearly state the learning objectives for role-plays and simulations so that participants know what they are learning and why. Understanding how training activities relate to career goals is an important source of motivation. Rubrics are effective for clarifying performance and assessment criteria.
- Provide frequent opportunities to practice and receive feedback. Research shows that communication skills increase with multiple exposures to simulation-based activities as compared to one-off sessions (Blackmore et al., 2018). Participants benefit from receiving explicit feedback on their performance both from the instructor and their peers. Recording role-plays is an effective tool for participants to self-assess their skills and identify areas for improvement.

Engagement

Incorporate diverse training activities and approaches linked to learning objectives.

Implementation Guidance (p. 112)



Practitioner Competency Framework

- SFS 2.1.1 Considers job requirements and skill importance and frequency of use to identify the most relevant Skills for Success domains for program design, delivery and assessment
- SFS 3.8.4 Incorporates role-play and simulation-based communication tasks
- SFS 3.8.7 Creates learning tasks that require participants to consider their own and others' perspectives, biases, purposes and intentions

Assessment Considerations

Communication skills are most commonly assessed through observation (live or recorded). The *Research Report to Support the Launch of Skills for Success* (2021) outlines the pros and cons of several other methods, such as task-based assessments, situational judgement tests, and subjective reports (see Table 2, p. 62).

Suggested approaches:

- Use scoring rubrics to assess performance-based tasks
  - Checklist ratings may allow for better standardization
  - Holistic ratings capture overall feeling and nuance
- Use audio recordings and select-response formats to assess listening skills so that scoring is not confounded with writing abilityUse audio recordings and select-response formats to assess listening skills so that scoring is not confounded with writing ability
- Adapt communication assessments from second language training contexts. Ensure that the content, purpose and context of the communication task is included as some language-based assessments may over-emphasize spelling, grammar and pronunciation.

Proficiency Levels:

Proficiency levels are the level at which a person demonstrates a particular skill. These levels help practitioners build assessment tools to measure participant's skills. The Office of Skills for Success will refine the proficiency levels over time.

Preliminary Proficiency Levels

Entry: You can speak and listen to a narrow range of subject matter, using factual and concrete language in predictable and familiar context, interacting one-on-one. You can use and interpret straightforward non-verbal cues (e.g., facial expression, eye contact).

Intermediate: You can speak and listen to a moderate range of subject matter, using both factual and abstract language. You can do this in less predictable contexts, interacting one-on-one or in small groups. You can interpret more complex non-verbal cues, including those with cultural implications, to better understand a speaker's intention and purpose.

Advanced: You can speak and listen to a wide range and depth of subject matter, using both factual and abstract or conceptual language. You can do this in a variety of contexts shifting from routine to unpredictable, and by interacting with familiar and unfamiliar audiences of various sizes. You can interpret complex and subtle non-verbal cues and use them to adapt their own communication styles.

Research Report to Support the Launch of Skills for Success (p. 48)

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GRAB AND GO TRAINING IDEAS

Activity	Communication Components	Instructional Tips	Sector-Specific
Ask participants to think of a time they had a miscommunication with someone on the job. Use a perspective-taking model, such as the DAE model, to analyze what happened from different angles and discuss different interpretations. The DAE MODEL: Describe what happened, Analyze what happened, and Evaluate what happened.	5. Adapt to your audience and contexts • *Identify and understand the needs, preferences, and interest of your audience, including differences in communication and interaction styles (e.g., culture, abilities)* • *Identify and understand contexts*	Encourage participants to brainstorm alternate points of view and challenge their own and their peers' assumptions. Provide a model or template to guide thinking processes and assist participants with skill acquisition (SFS 2.5.4). Model metacognition using think aloud step-by-step processes (SFS 2.5.6).	Generate sector-specific scenarios, based on miscommunications that commonly happen within the field.  Conduct interviews with trades workers to generate scenarios about cultural expectations surrounding speaking up and taking initiative on the jobsite.
As a group, brainstorm contexts at work that require strong listening skills. What are the consequences if listening is ineffective? Make a list of the characteristics of 'good' and 'bad' listening. How does it look, sound and feel? Follow-up with role-plays to practice demonstrating active listening skills.	1. Listen with intention (e.g., pay attention) • *Use appropriate body language to show that you are paying attention (e.g., do not fidget, maintain focus on the speaker), show support, or convey emotion* • *Ask questions to confirm your understanding*	Provide opportunities for participants to practice paraphrasing. Build intercultural competence by discussing how active listening may vary across cultures.	Contextualize listening skills to the sector.  Discuss strategies to overcome environmental noise on the jobsite. Link listening skills to safety, productivity and quality of work.
Provide small groups with sample scripts of instructions that a supervisor may provide to a worker. Participants take turns acting as the supervisor who gives the instructions and the worker who paraphrases what they heard to confirm understanding. Debrief strategies and challenges as a group. Discuss ways that supervisors can provide clear instructions.	1. Listen with intention (e.g., pay attention) • *Be able to summarize and paraphrase key points when needed* 2. Listen to understand • *Detect the speaker's purpose and intention* 4. Speak with purpose • *Convey a message such that the listener understands the purpose*	Provide explicit instruction on the definition, techniques and purposes of paraphrasing. Provide examples of paraphrased speech to serve as a model.	Contextualize the supervisor's instructions depending on the sector and role.  Sample script for Hotel Front Desk Clerk: *I've emailed you the VIP guest list. Please update it with the guests who are arriving this week. Make sure we have complete information for each guest. Sort the list by check-in time then save and share the file with me on SharePoint.e.g., Restaurant servers need to deal with customer demands and complaints. A common difficult interaction is when a customer is not satisfied with their meal and sends the food back or expects a refund.*

Collaboration

Collaboration is your ability to contribute and support others to achieve a common goal.

Why are Collaboration Skills Important?

Today people are more connected within communities, across the country, and around the world. Modern workplaces are more diverse, and many jobs require you to work with others from different backgrounds and cultures to complete tasks and solve problems. It is important to be able to work respectfully with people who have different professions, experiences, cultures, and backgrounds. Collaboration skills help you perform better in a team by understanding how to support and value others, manage difficult interactions, and contribute to the team's work. Strong collaboration skills help you build and maintain positive relationships with others at work, in school, and in other parts of your life.

Collaboration Components

1. Work well with other people
2. Value diversity and inclusivity of others
3. Manage difficult interactions with other people
4. Facilitate an environment where you can collaborate with others
5. Achieve a common goal with others
6. Reflect and improve on how well the team works together

Research Report to Support the Launch of Skills for Success (p. 27)

Sector	Workplace Examples
Construction	Sheet Metal Workers coordinate job tasks and share workspace and equipment with small groups of co-workers and larger project teams. They may coordinate activities with other tradespeople, to ensure the efficient use of workspaces, materials and time.
Manufacturing	Supervisors in motor vehicle assembling lead teams of production workers. They provide guidance and oversee activities to ensure quality control standards and production targets are met. They lead diverse teams of workers from different cultures, backgrounds and abilities.
Tourism	Retail Sales Associates work with co-workers to receive shipments, restock and prepare displays and customer orders. They attend staff meetings to share ideas and to solve specific issues, such as health and safety breaches, low sales and theft.
Forestry	Primary Production Labourers often work with partners or helpers to carry out tasks for which strength is required or which require one worker to monitor the safety of another. They may work and interact with co-workers who speak languages other than their own.

Transitioning from Essential Skills to Skills for Success

The Essential Skills Framework included the skill of Working with Others. In Skills for Success, it has been expanded to Collaboration, which includes inclusivity and respect for diversity.

Working with Others focused on coordination of tasks and recognition of roles and responsibilities. These elements are still included in Collaboration but with less emphasis. The new components highlight the social-emotional nature of interactions with coworkers and supporting others to achieve a common goal.

Practitioners can update their existing Essential Skills training materials by adding or re-emphasizing how diversity and inclusion and social-emotional skills impact working with others.

Evidence-Based Instructional Strategies

The following instructional strategies have been selected to highlight established or promising practices within the Skills for Success field and/or significant research that supports the instruction of collaboration skills.

1 Building Relationships

Research suggests that strong relationships are foundational to effective collaboration. Participants are more likely to make gains in their collaboration skills (and other skills) when they know each other, trust each other, work together and share information, ideas and goals (Crosnoe et al., 2004; see also Hughes & Kwok, 2007; Jennings & Greenberg, 2009; as cited in OECD, 2017). Practitioners can use the following strategies to foster a relationship-centered learning environment.

Instructional Strategies:

- Start training programs with icebreaker activities to help participants get to know each other and build relationships. This can be something as simple as sharing their names and something interesting about themselves or a more complex activity involving problem-solving or teamwork.
- Model collaborative, respectful and inclusive interactions with participants and other staff. The practitioner and the wider training community help set the tone and provide a model for participants to follow.

Engagement

Use a relationship-centred approach to engage learners.

Implementation Guidance (p. 109)

- Incorporate cooperative learning and group work throughout the training program. When participants work together on meaningful tasks, they have the opportunity to form stronger bonds.



Practitioner Competency Framework

- SFS 3.5.5 Incorporates activities to develop trust and psychological safety in team environments
- DELIVER 1.2.8 Helps participants to get to know each other, develop trust and build community

2 Explicit Instruction (Direct Instruction)

Collaboration skills do not tend to develop without explicit instruction. In other words, simply including a lot of cooperative learning and group work activities will not result in significant skill gains. Collaboration skills need to be explicitly taught.

Instructional Strategies:

- Spend time in class directly teaching collaboration skills, including strategies for interacting productively with others, resolving conflicts and managing taskwork. Use the components and subcomponents listed in the *Research Report to Support the Launch of Skills for Success* (2021) to guide your instruction (p. 25).
- Although collaboration skills are frequently used to learn other skills and knowledge, it is important to help participants develop collaboration skills as an end in themselves, not simply as a teaching method by which to learn other skills.
- Show and explain what good collaboration looks like. Collaboration includes elements of interpersonal communication, conflict resolution and task management. Design activities that require participants to use multiple elements of collaboration but provide feedback on each element individually.

Engagement



Strategically integrate social-emotional Skills for Success into training to maximize learning and skill gains.

Implementation Guidance (p. 111)

Note: See Approach #4 in Section 2 for more information about Direct Instruction.



Practitioner Competency Framework

- SFS 2.6 Provides direct instruction to structure and guide Skills for Success learning
- SFS 3.5.1 Provides explicit instruction on collaboration skills

3 Structured Guidance and Roles

Groups collaborate more effectively when they are provided with structured guidance. Just as participants need explicit instruction on collaboration skills, groups also need specific direction on how to work together. Practitioners can use the following strategies to help guide and structure collaborative tasks.

Instructional Strategies:

- Assign roles so that each member of the group has a specific job: e.g., facilitator, recorder, spokesperson, strategy analyst, etc. Roles can help increase awareness of task-coordination and lead to more equitable participation. Where possible, mimic the authentic roles of the workplace.
- Employ a variety of group formations to give participants experience in different collaborative settings. There is no magic group size, but smaller groups appear less prone to "social loafing" (Lai, 2017). Also, exposure to diversity in the training room is associated with better collaboration skills (OECD, 2017).
- Monitor collaboration tasks and intervene with guidance and feedback. Practitioner involvement encourages positive interaction and supports groups to stay on-task.



Practitioner Competency Framework

- SFS 2.6 Provides direct instruction to structure and guide Skills for Success learning
- SFS 3.5.4 Structures group interactions to encourage participation and individual accountability
- DELIVER 2.3.7 Incorporates a variety of small and large group discussion strategies

Assessment Considerations

Collaboration skills can be assessed in a variety of ways. The Research Report to Support the Launch of Skills for Success (2021) outlines the pros and cons of several methods, including task-based assessments, situational judgement tests and subjective reports (see Table 2, p. 62).

Suggested approaches:

- Assessment tasks need to be sufficiently complex and challenging, open-ended and context-based in order to encourage meaningful collaborative activity (Evans, 2020).
- To measure collaboration skills specifically, the assessment should focus on the quality of participant interactions, as opposed to the quality or quantity of the product(s) produced by the group (Lai, 2011).
- Recognize that in self-reporting and peer evaluations, participants are more likely to be honest in identifying what they could improve upon, if they know the information is only going to be used for formative rather than grading purposes (Evans, 2020).

Proficiency Levels:

Proficiency levels are the level at which a person demonstrates a particular skill. These levels help practitioners build assessment tools to measure participant's skills. The Office of Skills for Success will refine the proficiency levels over time.

Preliminary Proficiency Levels

Entry: You can interact with familiar people or a small number of diverse unfamiliar people to share information to complete routine independent tasks. You can maintain cooperative respectful behaviours toward others and minimize conflict.

Intermediate: You can work with familiar and diverse unfamiliar groups of people to coordinate tasks or work together to achieve simple or well-defined goals. You can support and adapt to others when appropriate and manage conflicts when needed.

Advanced: You can work in large teams of diverse people to achieve complex goals that might involve unpredictable situations. You can take on responsibility for integrating work, coaching and motivating others, managing conflicts, and evaluating and improving teamwork.

Research Report to Support the Launch of Skills for Success (p. 48)

RESOURCES:

- ABC Literacy. (2023). *Collaboration*. UP Skills for Work. https://upskillsforwork.ca/wp-content/uploads/ABC-UP-Collaboration.pdf
- Evans, C. (2020). *Measuring student success skills: A review of the literature on collaboration.* National Center for the Improvement of Educational Assessment. https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED607774.pdf
- Indeed Editorial Team. (2022). *17 effective icebreaker activities for groups of adults*. Indeed. https://ca.indeed.com/career-advice/career-development/icebreaker-activities-for-adults
- Lai, E. R., DiCerbo, K. E., & Foltz, P. (2017). *Skills for today: What we know about teaching and assessing collaboration.* Pearson. https://www.pearson.com/content/dam/one-dot-com/one-dot-com/global/Files/efficacy-and-research/skills-for-today/Collaboration-FullReport.pdf
- Maryville University. (n.d.) *Ice breakers & team builders.* https://www.maryville.edu/cse/wp-content/uploads/sites/62/2016/09/Icebreakers-Team-Builders.pdf
- Washington University in St. Louis. (n.d.). *Using roles in group work*. Center for Teaching and Learning. https://ctl.wustl.edu/resources/using-roles-in-group-work/
- Skills/Compétences Canada. (2022). *Workbook: Collaboration*. Skills for Success. https://yourskillsforsuccess.com/workbook/collaboration/



GRAB AND GO TRAINING IDEAS

Activity	Collaboration Components	Instructional Tips	Sector-Specific
Provide teams with a collaborative icebreaker task, such as a competition or problem-solving task. Do not pre-teach collaboration skills. Following the activity, ask teams to self-assess their team performance. What went well and what didn't? Provide components or criteria to assess themselves against. Identify strengths and areas for improvement as a team and as individuals.	5. Achieve a common goal with others • *Take responsibility to make contributions and complete tasks* • *Ensure opportunities for others to contribute* 6. Reflect and improve on how well the team works together • *Reflect on team performance* • *Make constructive suggestions for improvement*	Help participants recognize their natural inclinations in collaborative tasks and how these may help or hinder success. Ask participants to identify the contributions of their teammates. Focus on positive feedback initially. As trust develops, guide participants to provide constructive feedback to their peers.	Contextualize the collaborative icebreaker task to the sector. e.g., Groups of electrical apprentices work together to wire a circuit based on a schematic diagram or try to troubleshoot a faulty circuit.
Focus on social and organizational rules by giving each group the same or different jobs to analyze. Ask: What rules do workers need to follow? Next, participants identify which rules are workplace-specific and which would apply to all workplaces. Then ask participants to identify their experiences, strengths and areas for growth in adhering to these rules. Debrief together.	1. Work well with other people • *Adhere to social and organizational rules (e.g., be on time)* • *Assess strengths and weaknesses of yourself and others* 4. Facilitate an environment where you can collaborate with others • *Acknowledge roles of yourself and others*	Incorporate authentic workplace documents and materials where possible, such as employee handbooks. Build participants' intercultural competency by discussing similarities and differences in workplace rules in Canada and other countries.	Gather sector-specific workplace documents from employers. Build partnerships with training coordinators at sector-based unions, companies and other organizations. They may be willing to share employee handbooks, health and safety policies, etc. for training purposes. Some of these resources may be posted online.
Analyze effective conflict resolution. Ask participants to identify what specific behaviours they would see and hear during a conflict that was being handled effectively. Then provide a scenario involving a conflict or difficult interaction. Identify effective and ineffective behaviours. Ask participants to share how they would respond and why.	3. Manage difficult interactions with other people • *Engage in productive discussions* • *Anticipate and address interpersonal barriers* • *Discuss, negotiate, and resolve difficult interactions in a sensitive and helpful manner*	Teach strategies to stay calm and regulate emotions during conflict (SFS 2.8.4). Provide processes and models participants can use to resolve conflict (e.g., steps to follow, questions to ask themselves, etc.)	Contextualize the scenario to the sector and role. e.g., Restaurant servers need to deal with customer demands and complaints. A common difficult interaction is when a customer is not satisfied with their meal and sends the food back or expects a refund.

Adaptability

Adaptability is your ability to achieve or adjust goals and behaviours when expected or unexpected change occurs. Adaptability is shown by planning, staying focused, persisting and overcoming setbacks.

Why are Adaptability Skills Important?

Major changes in society affect how you work, live, and learn and require you to constantly adapt. Strong adaptability skills will help you deal effectively with change, and to learn new skills and behaviours when needed. They help you stay focused on your responsibilities and goals, and not give up when situations are difficult. Being adaptable helps you stay positive and manage the stress that can come from change in the workplace, community and your life at home.

Adaptability Components

1. Demonstrate responsibility
2. Persist and persevere
3. Regulate your emotions when appropriate
4. Set or adjust your goals and expectations
5. Plan and prioritize
6. Seek self-improvement

Research Report to Support the Launch of Skills for Success (p. 29)

Sector	Workplace Examples
Construction	Crane Operators adapt to new computerized crane control and monitoring systems that increase safety and efficiency.
Manufacturing	Industrial Mechanics (millwrights) must learn new skills as the scope of their work moves toward environmentally conscious hydroelectric construction projects such as "run of the river" that minimize human footprint.
Tourism	Flight Attendants respond to in-flight emergency situations. For instance, they deal with non-compliant passengers that violate safety policies such as those for reducing transmission of airborne viruses.
Bioeconomy	Biological Technologists learn about new technologies, products and equipment. They take short courses organized by their employer pertaining to OH&S, equipment operation or computer applications.

Transitioning from Essential Skills to Skills for Success

The Essential Skills Framework included the skill of Continuous Learning. While the concept of Adaptability was not explicitly stated in the Essential Skills framework, it was integrated within activities involving troubleshooting, adapting, dealing with challenging communication situations as well as learning new skills. In Skills for Success, Continuous Learning has been embedded into Adaptability.

In the Skills for Success model, Adaptability responds to the growing importance of soft and social-emotional skills in the labour market. It is interwoven with other skill competencies as people with good collaboration, communication and problem-solving skills are more adaptive to changing work and life situations. Adaptability is a foundational skill to success in training and employment.

Evidence-Based Instructional Strategies

The following instructional strategies have been selected to highlight established or promising practices within the Skills for Success field and/or significant research that supports the instruction of adaptability skills.

Teaching for adaptability can encompass a wide range of instructional methods. An integrated approach to instruction may be more efficient than a modular approach in order to tie together the major components, the considerable psychological component of emotional regulation, and account for personality traits and environmental factors.

1 Build a Growth Mindset

A mindset of self-improvement and growth is a key element of adaptability skills. Participants should be encouraged to believe in their capacity to improve their knowledge, abilities and intelligence.

Instructional Strategies:

- Coach participants why and how to receive feedback in a mentor/mentee dynamic. Feedback should be used to reinforce what they are doing well, and to learn where they've made mistakes and how to fix them. Kivunja (2015) lists a range of feedback strategies that can be used by instructors.
- When you give feedback to participants, focus on hard work and effort as opposed to framing success in terms of personality traits (Yeager & Dweck, 2012).
- Implement the Universal Design for Learning approach to stimulate participant interest and motivation. Participants build self-confidence in their learning abilities when offered appropriate accommodations.

Engagement



Incorporate a Universal Design for Learning (UDL) approach.

Implementation Guidance (p. 105)